

EPISODE

25. APPROACH *and* THRESHOLD

THE WAIT TERMINATES WHERE DESTINIES ALIGN.

Lisbon, Portugal

// 38.7223° N, 9.1393° W

SEPTEMBER 12, 2025 — 19:43 WEST



EPISODE 25



TIME ISN'T THE
ENEMY.
ALIGNMENT IS.

DESCENT INTO
LISBON.
23:41 LOCAL.

THE CITY
ARRIVES
IN LAYERS.

FIRST, THE TAGUS.
A DARK RIBBON.

THEN, THE BRIDGE
LIGHTS.

THEN, THE FIRST
WARM GRID OF
STREETS.



EVERYTHING IS
AS IT SHOULD BE.

A NORMAL ARRIVAL.
A NORMAL NIGHT.

Cabin crew, prepare for landing.

We'll be touching down in Lisbon
in approximately 9 minutes.

23:32
Sunday, June 22

9 MINUTES.

A DISCREPANCY TOO SMALL
TO MATTER.

ANNOUNCEMENT

23:41

- 09:00

PHONE CLOCK

23:32

OR SO IT
PRETENDS.

CONTINUED...

LISBON AIRPORT
ARRIVALS HALL — DAWN
06:41 WEST

THE BUILDING
DOESN'T JUST
PROCESS PEOPLE.

IT SCHEDULES
THEM.

CHEGADAS
ARRIVALS →

BAGAGEM | CUSTOMS

ZONA PROIBIDA
NO PARKING AREA

3NZ Aeroportos
de Portugal

CHEGADAS | ARRIVALS 06:41

TIME	FROM	FLIGHT	STATUS
06:18	LONDON (LHR)	TP1362	LANDED
06:25	MADRID (MAD)	IB531	LANDED
06:32	TOKYO (NRT)	TP075	LANDED
06:40	PARIS (CDG)	AF1824	LANDED
06:45	FRANKFURT (FRA)	LH1176	EXPECTED

WELCOME TO LISBON

KAI MORI

06:32

WED, 14 MAY
WEST

SYNC DELAY
-00:09:00

REIKA TENDO

06:41

WED, 14 MAY
WEST

TIME SYNC
+00:00:00

3NZ Aeroportos
de Portugal

EQUIPMENT
CONTROL TAG

DATE

15/05

ID 872-LIS

TOMORROW'S
TAG.

PARKED
WHERE IT
SHOULDN'T
BE.

SORA MINABE.
YOU NOTICE
THINGS.

GOOD.
KEEP
WATCHING.

LISBON. PORTUGAL.

09:17



rent a car

Saída Exit

OK, OK—
O CARRO É PEQUENO,
MAS FAZ BEM O TRABALHO.
MANUAL, DIESEL, MUITO
ECONÓMICO. TANGUE CHEIO
QUANDO PEGAR, DEVOLVE
CHEIO. MULTA SE NÃO.

ZONA VERDE—ESTACIONA
LÁ. NÃO, NÃO LÁ. MAIS
ADIANTE. VAI VER NO
MAPA. TUDO AQUI.

O APARTAMENTO É...
EH... NUM ACORDO
TEMPORÁRIO, TÁ?

QUALQUER COISA, LIGA. NÚMERO AÍ.

OBRIGADO! BOA
ESTADIA!

GOLDCAR

KAI MORI.
EVERY MOVEMENT
A LINE. EVERY
SILENCE A
CHOICE.

REIKA TENDO.
SHE DOESN'T
ASK TWICE.

SORA MINABE.
HE READS WHAT
OTHERS DON'T
SAY.

LISBOA

Miradouro
da Graça

Castelo
de S. Jorge

Alfama

Baixa
(ruas)

Chiado

Cais do
Sodré

Padrão dos
Descobrimentos

Belém

RIO TEJO

NÃO É O
CAMINHO MAIS CURTO.
É O CAMINHO QUE
IMPORTA.
BOA VIAGEM.
→?

SOME MAPS DON'T
SHOW A PLACE,
THEY REVEAL A PLAN.

AMOREIRAS
SHOPPING CENTER
ROOFTOP

LISBON, PORTUGAL
LATE MORNING



THE VIEW SHOULD
BE REFRESHING.
INSTEAD, IT FEELS
EXPOSED.
LIKE THE CITY
IS WATCHING BACK.

KAI MORI
AGE: 17



READING
URBAN PATTERN...

LET'S SEE WHAT
TODAY DECIDES
TO REVEAL.



AN ABSENCE.
AS IF THE CITY
REMEMBERS A
CHOICE NOT TAKEN.

REIKA TENDO
AGE: 18



THE STREETS
DON'T LINE UP.
THIS WASN'T
ALWAYS THE
PATTERN.



AN OLDER GRID.
THE CITY,
REDRAWN.

SORA MINABE
AGE: 16



THE FUTURE
HAS HEIGHT.
HEIGHT
DOESN'T OWE US
ANSWERS.

WE CAME UP HERE
LOOKING FOR CLARITY.
ALL WE GOT
WAS ACCURACY.



AND ACCURACY
CAN BE ITS OWN
KIND OF ACCUSATION.



MARQUÊS DE POMBAL SQUARE

LISBON, PORTUGAL

11:47 AM

THE TRAFFIC DOESN'T
FLOW.
IT OBBITS.

SAME PATTERN.
DIFFERENT BEAT.

THE WORLD
REPEATS WITHOUT
ADMITTING IT.



KAI MORI
NOTES THE
SHADOWS THAT
DON'T BELONG.

REIKA TENDO
NOTICES WHAT
OTHERS DON'T
QUESTION.

SORA MINABE
FEELS THE WEIGHT
OF LOOKING OUT
IN THE OPEN.



THE SUN IS
HERE.

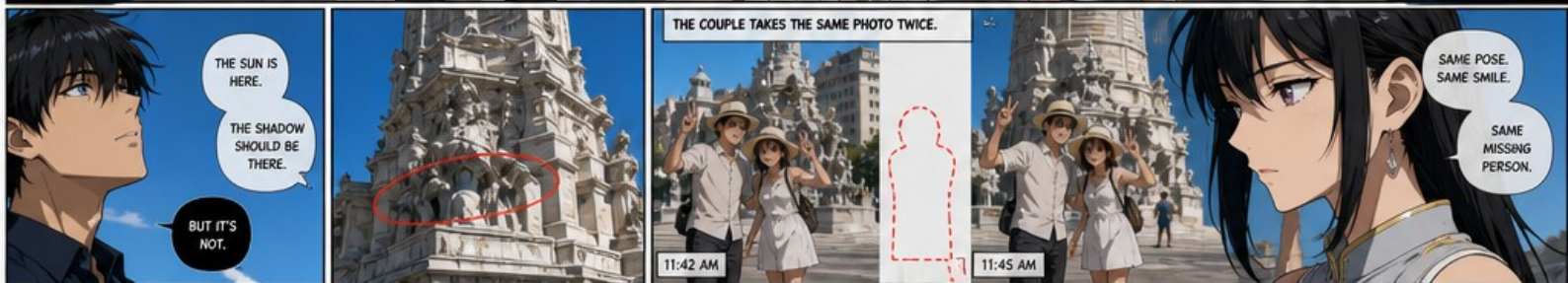
THE SHADOW
SHOULD BE
THERE.

BUT IT'S
NOT.

THE COUPLE TAKES THE SAME PHOTO TWICE.

SAME POSE.
SAME SMILE.

SAME MISSING
PERSON.



NOT RANDOM.

REPLAY.

PRECISE.
RELENTLESS.



NOWHERE
TO HIDE.

NOWHERE
TO BLEND.

EVERYONE
IS WATCHING.

EVEN IF THEY
DON'T KNOW
IT YET.



EDUARDO VIII PARK,
LISBON.

THE LIGHT IS
TOO CLEAN.
TOO BEAUTIFUL.

BEAUTY
THAT MAKES
ROOM FOR
UNEASE.

KAI
STOPS.

THE PRESENT-
TRUTH AROUND
THIS LAWN
IS HARD TO
PIN DOWN.

THE BENCH
IS SHOWN AS
RECENTLY PAINTED...

...AND
SIMULTANEOUSLY
WEATHERED BY
YEARS OF SUN.

REIKA
TOUCHES THE
TOP RAIL—

—AND SEES
A PAST THAT
DOES NOT
BELONG TO
THIS PARK.

SORA
SITS.

HE REALIZES
HE CAN'T
GET A CLEAR
FUTURE FROM
THIS LAWN
AT ALL.

NOT LISBON.
ANOTHER CITY.
ANOTHER TIME.

THE HORIZON
KEEPS
DISSOLVING
INTO WHITE
GLARE.

A BEAUTIFUL
PUBLIC OPENNESS

MADE
UNNERVING BY
ITS OWN SCALE.

A SILENT TRAP
WITH NO WALLS.

AVENIDA DA LIBERDADE.
LISBON.
17:42.
BEAUTIFUL.
EXPENSIVE.
DECEPTIVELY
PERFECT.

KAI MORI.
STRATEGIST.
SEES PATTERNS.
TRUSTS NONE.

REIKA TENDO.
COMMAND PRESENCE.
ZERO TOLERANCE FOR
CHAOS.

SORA MINABE.
SENSITIVE.
FEELS FIRST.
WORRIES ALWAYS.

THAT TRAM—
IT PASSED.
A FULL FIVE
SECONDS AGO.

REFLECTION:
DELAYED.
OBSERVATION:
ACCURATE.

SAME WOMAN.
SAME GESTURE.
TWICE.
IMPOSSIBLE.

I REACH
FORWARD—
NOTHING.
JUST...

...BLANK.

THE NEXT HOUR
ISN'T HIDING.
IT'S NOT THERE.

THE AVENUE
REFUSES TO
FORECAST ITSELF.

THE REFLECTIONS
ARE HONEST.
THE STREET
ISN'T.

KLAK.

Cartier

SÃO BENTO DISTRICT.
NEAR THE PARLIAMENT.
LISBON.



THE SOUND IS
ORDINARY.
BUT IT SEEMS
TO CUT THE
SCENE IN HALF.

KLANG—
KLANG—

REIKA LOOKS
AT THE FAÇADE
AND GETS A
FLASH OF A
PRIOR ERA:

DOCUMENTS.
SIGNATURES.
A HAND
CLOSING
A FOLDER.

CÂMARA MUNICIPAL
DE LISBOA
Acta n.º 1247
Sessão Ordinária
de 12 de Julho de 1994
O Presidente.
Shachisatani

KAI CATCHES
A PRESENT-TRUTH
READING ON
A MUNICIPAL
NOTICE BOARD—

EDITAL
REUNIÃO DE CÂMARA
PÚBLICA
12 JUL 2024 10:00
19 JUL 2024 10:00
CÂMARA MUNICIPAL
DE LISBOA

THAT BRIEFLY
SHOWS TWO
DIFFERENT MEETING
DATES LAYERED
OVER EACH OTHER.

SORA NOTES
THE WAY PEOPLE
STEP AROUND
THE TRAM TRACKS
WITHOUT LOOKING
DOWN.

AS IF EVERYONE
ALREADY KNOWS
THIS PLACE
CARRIES
CONSEQUENCES.

PAST.

PRESENT.

FUTURE.

JARDIM FERNANDO PESSOA
CAMPO DE OURIQUE, LISBOA
16:42



REIKA TOUCHES
A BENCH.

THE WOOD IS WARM.
THE MEMORY IS NOT.



SOMEONE SAT HERE
MANY EVENINGS AGO.

WAITING FOR A
CONVERSATION
THAT NEVER
ARRIVED.



A RESONANCE.
NOT HER OWN.



KAI NOTICES
THE FLYER.

A HANDWRITTEN
CORRECTION.
IN PEN.

OVER OFFICIAL
TIME.

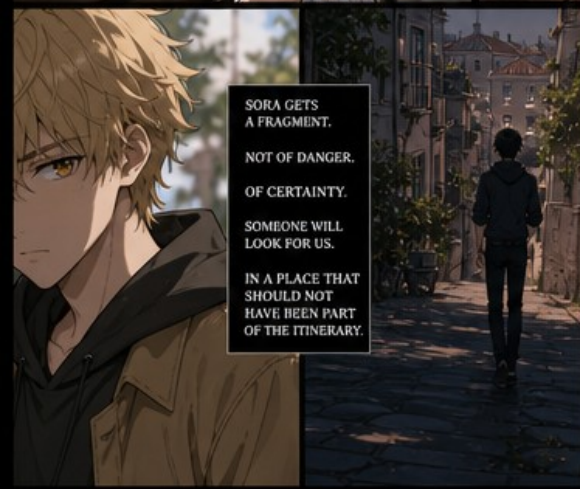


SORA GETS
A FRAGMENT.

NOT OF DANGER.
OF CERTAINTY.

SOMEONE WILL
LOOK FOR US.

IN A PLACE THAT
SHOULD NOT
HAVE BEEN PART
OF THE ITINERARY.



IT IS ALREADY
DECIDED.

WE ARE JUST
LATE TO KNOW.



HOMENAGEM A
ALGUÉM QUE GOSTAVA
DE CONVERSAS.





THE TAGUS DOESN'T
FLOW.
IT REMEMBERS.

AND LISBON
STANDS HERE
LIKE A PROMISE
IT WON'T LET
YOU KEEP.

BEAUTIFUL
ENOUGH TO
BE DISARMING.

EVERY LINE
IS A BORDER.



KAI MORI
SEES HIS OWN
REFLECTION
LAG BY A
FRACTION OF
A SECOND.



REIKA TENDO
TOUCHES THE
COLD METAL
AND CATCHES
A HISTORY OF
DEPARTURES.

PEOPLE LEAVING.
RETURNING.
MISSING ONE
ANOTHER.

WAITING AT
THE WRONG
SHORELINE.

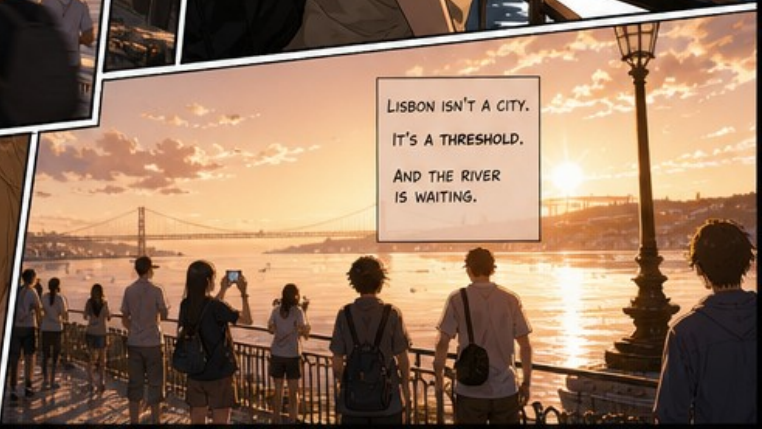


SORA MINABE

WATCHES THE
FERRY APPROACH
AND FEELS THE
FUTURE COLLAPSE
INTO A BLANK
WHITE STRIP.



LISBON ISN'T A CITY.
IT'S A THRESHOLD.
AND THE RIVER
IS WAITING.



THE DISTRICT
REMEMBERS
OTHER WALKS.

OTHER NAMES.
OTHER NIGHTS.

KAI TURNS ONE CORNER
AND SEES A STREET THAT
APPEARS TO LOOP BACK
ONTO ITSELF.

REIKA HEARS A LAUGH
FROM ABOVE THAT
SEEMS TO REPEAT
ONE BEAT TOO LATE.

HA!

...HA!

SORA SEES A FUTURE
FRAGMENT—A STRANGER
SAYING THEIR NAMES
BEFORE THEY EVEN
INTRODUCE THEMSELVES.

KAI.
REIKA.
SORA.

THE WORDS HAVE
NOT BEEN SPOKEN.
YET THEY ALREADY
ECHO.

BEAUTIFUL.
FAMILIAR.
IMPOSSIBLE.



Would you like the same table again?



LISBON FELL
BEHIND US IN
LATE AFTERNOON.

THE ROAD OPENED
TOWARD DUNES
AND THE SEA.

SORA FELT
THE OCEAN
BEFORE HE
SAW IT.

HE COULDN'T
DECIDE IF THE
FUTURE WAS
CLEARER HERE—

—OR WORSE.

REIKA NOTICED
A SIGN WHERE
THE PRESENT
NAME DIDN'T
FULLY ERASE
THE PAST.

KAI READ
THE PRESENT
OF THE COASTLINE.

HE GOT A SHARP,
USELESS SENSE
THAT THE SEA
WAS BEING
CAREFUL—

—NOT TO REVEAL
ITSELF ALL AT ONCE.

Costa da Caparica →

COSTA DE CAPARICA

17:42
27°C

THE RELIEF
OF WIDER SKY.

THE UNEASE
OF DISTANCE
THAT REFUSED
TO CHANGE.

THE OCEAN
REMAINED
BEYOND THE DUNES.

STILL
THE SAME
DISTANCE
AWAY.

KAI MORI

Everything
leaves a mark.

Even what was
never here.

SORA MINABE

The light
isn't the future.

It's just what's
left.

REIKA TENDO

Some places
don't remember
you.

They remember
someone else.

The tide
remembers
better than
we do.

It keeps what
we try to
forget.

Touch.

And the skin
remembers
what the mind
buried.

Another beach.
Another day.
Another almost.

Tomorrow
was here.

Then it folded.

Then it was
gone.

LISBON, PORTUGAL.
23:41.



THE KETTLE IS
STILL WARM.



THE CLOCK
HAS JUMPED.
NINE MINUTES
AHEAD.



A SHEET OF PAPER.
THIN. OUT OF PLACE.
NOT OURS.



THE NEXT FEW
MINUTES SLIP.
NOT TIME—
PERCEPTION.



THE APARTMENT
FEELS EXPECTED.
NOT EMPTY.
NOT VACANT.
...AWAITING.



GUESTS?
OBSERVERS?
OR ALREADY
EXPECTED?